

EASTERN MEDITERRANEAN UNIVERSITY
DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE AND INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS
SPRING 2025

COURSE CODE: PSIR 308
COURSE TITLE: CONTEMPORARY POLITICAL THOUGHT
COURSES LEVEL: 3rd Year - Undergraduate
COURSE TYPE: Area Core
CREDIT VALUE: 3 Credit Hours
ECTS: 6
PREREQUISITES: PSIR 307

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Office Hours: Mondays 12:30-14:20, Tuesdays: 12:30-13:20 or by appointment

CATALOGUE DESCRIPTION

This course aims to survey the contemporary political thought of the 20th century. It concentrates on the most influential trends in Marxist, liberal, and communitarian political thought.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

This semester this course aims to introduce students to contemporary political thought and debates from the post-WWII period. Our investigation of contemporary political thought will be organized around debates surrounding some key political concepts, such as justice, equality, freedom, citizenship, multiculturalism, and feminism. We will be reading Will Kymlicka's seminal book *Contemporary Political Thought*. It is not light a book, sure, but it is one of the best books in the market one could get as an introduction to the debates concerning contemporary political thought. Yes, reading the book is COMPULSORY. We will supplement the book with critics and others who challenge Kymlicka's multiculturalist perspective.

Specific objectives include providing the students with:

- Awareness on a more comprehensive understanding of "political" and "politics".
 - Awareness on various political problems that continue to plague the world.
 - Understanding of different contemporary schools of thought and how they relate to Liberalism.
 - Skills of critical thinking and formulating their own thoughts on key political concepts.
 - Skills to make sense of political phenomena in a theoretically-grounded manner.
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GENERAL LEARNING OUTCOMES

Upon successful completion of this course, students are expected to have developed a good understanding of different contemporary political debates and theoretical challenges to Liberalism, be able to think critically and utilize different theories to analyze contemporary political phenomena.

GRADING CRITERIA:

"A" indicates excellent performance with clear evidence of:

Comprehensive knowledge of the subject matter and principles treated in the course, a high degree of originality and independence of thought, a superior ability to organize and analyze ideas, and an outstanding ability to communicate.

"B" indicates good performance with evidence of:

Substantial knowledge of the subject matter, a moderate degree of originality and independence of thought, a good ability to organize and analyze ideas, and an ability to communicate clearly and fluently.

"C" indicates satisfactory performance with evidence of:

An acceptable grasp of the subject matter, some ability to organize and analyze ideas, and an ability to

communicate adequately.

"D" indicates minimally acceptable performance with evidence of:

Rudimentary knowledge of the subject matter, some evidence that organizational and analytical skills have been developed, but with significant weaknesses in some areas, and a significant weakness in the ability to communicate.

"F" indicates failing performance with evidence of:

An inadequate knowledge of the subject matter, failure to complete required work, an inability to organize and analyze ideas, and an inability to communicate.

REVISED METHOD OF ASSESSMENT

Component	Weight	Description
Class Participation	10%	Active and meaningful participation in class discussions, online activities, and group work. Silence is not encouraged.
Weekly Reflection Posts & Reading Journals	10%	Short critical reflections and analysis of weekly readings.
Policy Memos	20%	Two written policy memos applying theoretical perspectives to contemporary political issues.
Group Presentations	10%	In-class group presentations connecting theories to real-world case studies.
Midterm Exam	20%	In-class essay-based assessment focusing on critical analysis of core readings and theories.
Final Exam	30%	Comprehensive essay-based exam covering all course content.

CLASS ATTENDANCE AND PARTICIPATION

Attendance will be taken every class. Active participation is a key element of your grade. A minimum of 80% attendance is required per university regulations. Absences exceeding 20% of total class hours may result in an "NG" grade.

GRADING CRITERIA

Grade	Score Range
A	85 – 100
A-	80 – 84
B+	75 – 79
B	70 – 74
B-	66 – 69
C+	63 – 65
C	60 – 62
C-	57 – 59
D+	54 – 56
D	50 – 53
D- / FAIL	45 – 49
F / FAIL	0 – 44

MAKE-UP EXAM AND WRITTEN ASSIGNMENTS POLICY

Make-up exams will only be given in the following circumstances:

- Sickness on the day of the main examination - provided you produce a medical certificate certified by the university authorities;
- An Examination timetable clash - provided you produce written evidence of the clash;
- Other exceptional circumstances – again provided you produce written evidence.

In all cases, you must submit a written request for a Make-up Examination via the Departmental Secretary (who will sign and date it) within three working days of the main examination giving reasons together with the necessary supporting evidence.

All other requests for make-up examinations will be refused and a mark of "0" will be entered for the examination concerned.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Plagiarism, cheating and other forms of academic dishonesty will not be tolerated in this class. Any examination or assignment tainted by academic dishonesty will **at least** automatically receive a grade of F. University regulations also require reporting of incidents of academic dishonesty, which may lead to probation of two semesters from the University. **If you have any questions about what constitutes plagiarism, contact me before submitting your assignments.**

Plagiarism and cheating are punishable through medium or long term suspension under the Student Disciplinary Code By-law (see 6 (d)(i) of S99/175-12).

All cases of cheating on examinations will be forwarded to Disciplinary Committee.

Written assignments that are taken **in full or in part** from any source (printed or internet) without clear identification of all direct **quotes and paraphrases or ideas** are considered cases of **plagiarism**. Written assignments that have been prepared in full or in part by persons other than those who submitted the assignment, or the use of notes or copying in exams, or the submission of the same essay to different classes, are considered cases of **cheating**.

There are now AI thresholds built into Turnitin, so please also be mindful that a high threshold may also be treated as a case of plagiarism. I will discuss how this works in class.

READING MATERIALS

Contemporary Political Thought, Will Kymlicka, Oxford University Press

An electronic copy of the book is available online. Supplemental readings will also be made available online through the LMS Moodle.

COURSE OUTLINE WITH WEEKLY TOPICS, READINGS & ACTIVITIES

Week	Subject	Readings	Activities & Assignments
25-26/02	Introduction to the Course - Overview of Contemporary Political Thought - Syllabus Walkthrough	Kymlicka, <i>Introduction</i>	- Weekly Reflection Post #1: Personal aims & expectations. - Introduction to collaborative annotation tool.
05-06/03	Introduction (cont.) - Core concepts & key debates in 20th-century political thought	Kymlicka, <i>Ch. 1</i>	- Reading Journal: Identify one key concept from Ch. 1. - Small-Group Discussion: Mapping justice, equality, and freedom.
11-12/03	Utilitarianism - Historical context & contemporary influence	Kymlicka, <i>Ch. 2</i> Short excerpt from J.S. Mill's <i>Utilitarianism</i>	- Policy Analysis Exercise: Evaluate a policy using utilitarian logic. - Weekly Reflection Post #2.
18-19/03	Liberal Equality (Part 1) - Rawlsian approaches	Kymlicka, <i>Ch. 3 (pp. 53-75)</i> Excerpt from John Rawls, <i>A Theory of Justice</i>	- Reading Journal: Summarize Rawls's "difference principle." - In-Class Debate Prep: "Should the state reduce inequality?"
25-26/03	Liberal Equality (Part 2) - Nozick's libertarian critique	Kymlicka, <i>Ch. 3 (pp. 75-102)</i> Excerpt from Robert	- In-Class Debate: "Redistributive Justice vs. Minimal State." - Weekly

Week	Subject	Readings	Activities & Assignments
		Nozick, <i>Anarchy, State, and Utopia</i>	Reflection Post #3 (Rawls vs. Nozick).
02/04	Libertarianism & Citizenship Theory - Individual rights vs. state authority - Republican vs. liberal citizenship	Kymlicka, Ch. 4 (pp. 102–128) Kymlicka, Ch. 7	- Short Policy Memo #1: Propose a policy solution using libertarian or egalitarian principles. - Weekly Reflection Post #4: Evaluate a citizenship law.
08-09/04	Marxism - Marxist critique of liberalism	Kymlicka, Ch. 5 (pp. 166–208) Short excerpt from <i>The Communist Manifesto</i>	- Policy Memo #1 Due. - Group Presentation Sign-Ups (on Marxist movements).
11-26/04	Midterm Examinations	No new readings	- Midterm Exam (Essay-based).
29-30/04	Communitarianism - Critiques of liberalism	Kymlicka, Ch. 6 (pp. 208–284) Excerpt from Charles Taylor or Michael Sandel	- Reading Journal: Communitarian critique of liberal universalism. - In-Class Simulation: "Town hall" on mandatory vaccination vs. community rights.
06-07/05	Multiculturalism - Group rights, cultural diversity, minority protection	Kymlicka, Ch. 8 Optional: Nancy Fraser on "Recognition vs. Redistribution"	Small-Group Discussion: Multicultural policy debates.
13-14/05	Feminism - Liberal vs. radical feminism, intersectionality	Kymlicka, Ch. 9 Excerpt from bell hooks or Nancy Fraser	- Take-Home Exam Due (May 25). - In-Class Debate: "Are gender quotas necessary?" - Weekly Reflection Post #5: Intersectional critiques.
20-21/05	Review & Synthesis - Reviewing Ch. 1–9	Kymlicka, Ch. 1–9 (Review)	- In-Class Roundtable: Most convincing theory? - Q&A session for Final Exam.
11-26/06	Final Examination Period	No new readings	- Final Exam (Essay-based). - (Optional) Mini-Conference: Present final papers linking theory to a contemporary issue.

ASSIGNMENTS AND INSTRUCTIONS

- Weekly Reflection Posts** (150–200 words)
 - Summarize a key idea and pose a critical question.
 - Submit via LMS before class.
 - Reading Journals** (~200 words)
 - Focus on a key theoretical argument from the readings.
 - Submitted before class.
 - In-Class Debates & Simulations**
 - Teams will prepare arguments based on Kymlicka and additional sources.
 - Graded on clarity, relevance, and teamwork.
 - Policy Memos** (500–700 words)
 - Two short memos identifying a policy issue and applying a theoretical framework.
 - Justify proposals with references to readings.
 - Group Presentations** (10–15 minutes)
 - Presentations on historical/contemporary cases tied to course theories.
 - Visual aids recommended.
 - Take-Home Exam** (~1000 words)
 - Synthesis of multiple theories in response to provided questions.
 - Submit via Turnitin.
 - Midterm & Final Exams**
 - In-class essay-based assessments covering key theoretical debates.
 - Optional Mini-Conference**
 - Short presentations linking course theory to a contemporary issue.
 - Encourages research and discussion.
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Course policies regarding attendance, academic integrity, and make-up exams remain unchanged. Dates may be adjusted per university guidelines.